

Native Plant Division Guide

Western Australian native species – Joondalup, WA

Version 1.0 · September 2026 · 5 species

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Moderate-Difficult *

* Provisional rating – based on related plants; confirm with your own nursery records.

Compiled from published sources (see References). Windows and ratings are starting points for local practice.

How to use this guide

Division means splitting one plant into several pieces that each already have roots. It is the quickest way to multiply clump-forming plants such as kangaroo paws, flax lilies and tufted grasses, and every new plant is identical to its parent. Each species has its own page set, listed alphabetically: quick facts, a division calendar, a plant snapshot, the method, common problems and a record table.

Divide nursery stock plants, not plants from bushland. Timing is written for the Joondalup / Perth coastal climate: most clumps are best divided in autumn so the pieces root before winter.

Species index – at a glance

Species	Page	Difficulty	Division type	Best months	Division size
<i>Anigozanthos manglesii</i> Red and Green Kangaroo Paw	6	Moderate	Rhizome clump division	Mar – May	3+ shoots with roots
<i>Austrostipa flavescens</i> Coast Speargrass	8	Moderate *	Tussock division	Apr – Jun	Small clumps, 3–5 tillers
<i>Dianella revoluta</i> Blueberry Lily / Flax Lily	10	Easy	Rhizome clump division	Mar – May	3–4 shoots with rhizome
<i>Spinifex hirsutus</i> Hairy Spinifex	12	Moderate–Difficult *	Tussock division	Mar – May	Rooted clumps with runners
<i>Spinifex longifolius</i> Beach Spinifex	14	Moderate–Difficult *	Tussock division	Mar – May	Rooted clumps with runners

* Provisional rating – based on related plants; update once your own results are recorded.

Division calendar

Species	Jan	Feb	Mar	Apr	May	Jun	Jul	Aug	Sep	Oct	Nov	Dec
<i>Anigozanthos manglesii</i>	–	OK	Best	Best	Best	OK	–	–	OK	OK	–	–
<i>Austrostipa flavescens</i>	–	–	OK	Best	Best	Best	OK	–	–	–	–	–
<i>Dianella revoluta</i>	–	OK	Best	Best	Best	OK	–	OK	OK	OK	–	–
<i>Spinifex hirsutus</i>	OK	OK	Best	Best	Best	–	–	–	OK	OK	OK	OK
<i>Spinifex longifolius</i>	OK	OK	Best	Best	Best	–	–	–	OK	OK	OK	OK
Perth season	Summer		Autumn			Winter			Spring		Sum.	
Best window	Workable – slower to re-establish or needs more care					Avoid / low success						

Other species that can be divided or layered

These have no page in this guide because another method works better, but they can be split, or rooted pieces lifted, when stock plants allow.

Species	How	Main method
<i>Carpobrotus virescens</i>	Lift stems that have rooted – treat as cuttings.	Cuttings
<i>Grevillea vestita</i>	Can sucker – lift rooted suckers.	Cuttings
<i>Hibbertia racemosa</i>	Low stems may root where they touch the soil (layering).	Cuttings
<i>Lechenaultia linarioides</i>	Some lechenaultias sucker – pot up rooted suckers.	Cuttings
<i>Scaevola canescens</i>	Only if stems have rooted or suckered.	Cuttings
<i>Scaevola globulifera</i>	Check stock plants for rooted stems.	Cuttings
<i>Scaevola repens</i>	Some scaevolae sucker; check for rooted pieces.	Cuttings
<i>Scaevola thesioides</i>	Only if stock plants have suckered.	Cuttings

Types of division

Type	What it is	Examples
Clump / rhizome	Grass-like clumps with a creeping underground stem. Cut into pieces of rhizome, each with shoots and roots.	<i>Anigozanthos</i> , <i>Dianella</i> , <i>Lomandra</i> , <i>Patersonia</i>
Tussock	True grasses. Split a clump into smaller clumps of shoots (tillers) with roots.	<i>Austrostipa</i> , <i>Spinifex</i>
Suckers	New shoots arising from roots a short way from the parent. Dig up with roots attached and pot individually.	Some <i>Lechenaultia</i> , <i>Scaevola</i> , <i>Grevillea</i>
Layering	Stems that root where they touch the soil. Cut into rooted pieces and pot up, or pin a stem into a pot beside the parent.	<i>Hibbertia</i> , <i>Carpobrotus</i> , spinifex runners

Based on ANPSA's propagation notes (source 1).

Difficulty ratings

Rating	Meaning
Easy	Divisions re-establish reliably with the standard method.
Easy-Moderate	Usually re-establish; one factor (e.g. moisture, size of piece) needs care.
Moderate	Re-establish, but results depend on timing, piece size and aftercare.
Moderate-Difficult	Many divisions fail; another method is usually better.
Difficult	Rarely successful; use another method.

Confidence

Level	Meaning
High	A published division method exists for the species or genus.
Medium	Based on closely related plants or general practice for this plant type. Verify with trials.
Low	Little information available; treat as a trial protocol.

Standard division method

Species pages note where a species differs.

Step	What to do
1. Choose stock	Healthy, vigorous, pest- and disease-free nursery plants with plenty of shoots. Label each stock plant's provenance.
2. Time it	Warmer months give the best results; late-summer to autumn divisions root well before winter (ANPSA). Summer divisions need extra shelter.
3. Water first	Water the stock plant the day before so roots and shoots are full of water.
4. Lift and clean	Lift the clump or knock it out of its pot. Shake or wash off the mix so you can see where to cut.
5. Divide	Cut with a clean, sharp knife or spade. Aim for pieces with three or four leaf shoots , a good section of rhizome and healthy roots (ANPSA). Smaller pieces need a humid house.
6. Trim	Cut off damaged roots. Cut leaves back by about one-third to reduce water loss.
7. Pot	Pot into a free-draining mix with shoots at the same level as before . Firm in and water well.
8. Shelter	Keep in a sheltered, shaded spot (or humid house for small pieces) until new leaves grow and roots show at the drainage holes. Small divisions typically need 4–6 weeks.
9. Harden off	About a week with nights exposed, then a week in a sheltered spot, then into the open (ANPSA).
10. Pot on	Pot on or plant out once roots fill the pot.

Hygiene

Topic	Guidance
Tools	Clean, sharp knives and spades. Wipe with alcohol between stock plants.
Disease	Don't divide plants showing disease. Kangaroo paws are prone to ink disease (black leaf spots); many WA natives are susceptible to <i>Phytophthora</i> – keep pots off the ground and use fresh mix.
Collecting	Digging plants from bushland needs a DBCA licence and landholder permission. Divide nursery stock instead, and label every batch with its source.

Anigozanthos manglesii

Red and Green Kangaroo Paw

Family
Haemodoraceae

DIFFICULTY	DIVISION TYPE				BEST MONTHS			DIVISION SIZE		TIME TO ESTABLISH		
Moderate	Rhizome clump division				Mar – May			3+ shoots with roots		4–6 weeks sheltered		
	Jan	Feb	Mar	Apr	May	Jun	Jul	Aug	Sep	Oct	Nov	Dec
Division	–	OK	Best	Best	Best	OK	–	–	OK	OK	–	–
	Best window	Workable – slower to re-establish or needs more care										

Plant snapshot

Habit	Rhizomatous perennial herb, 0.2–1.1 m (flower stems). Often short-lived – best treated as a 2–3 year plant.
Flowering	Aug – Nov (green and red). WA's floral emblem.
Habitat	White, yellow or grey sand and sandy loam.
Local note	Recorded in the Wanneroo LGA. Less vigorous and shorter-lived than most garden hybrids.

Propagation options

Method	Suitability	Notes	Details in
Cuttings	Not used	Clumping herb – no stems to cut.	–
Seed	Main method	Dry heat or aged seed; autumn sowing.	→ Seed Sowing Guide
Division	Good	Split vigorous clumps into rhizome pieces with shoots and roots.	This guide

Division method

Item	Details
Best time to divide	Mar – May – ANPSA says clumps are best divided in autumn, though other times also work. Feb, Jun and Sep – Oct are workable; summer divisions need protection until re-established. Avoid Jul – Aug (cold, wet) and Nov – Jan (heat).
Division type	Rhizome clump division – the clump is cut into pieces of rhizome, each with leaf shoots and roots.
Division size	At least three large shoots per piece gives the best chance of success (ANPSA). Single-shoot pieces with some roots can work but need a humid glasshouse until new roots form.
Selecting stock	Vigorous, healthy clumps, ideally in their second year – this species is often short-lived. Don't divide plants with black leaf spotting (ink disease).
Preparation	- Water the stock plant the day before. - Lift the clump (or knock it out of its pot) and shake or wash off the mix so you can see the rhizome. - Cut through the rhizome with a clean, sharp knife. - Trim damaged roots. - Cut all leaves back by about one-third to reduce water loss (ANPSA).
Potting	Pot into a well-drained potting mix with the shoots at the same level as before (ANPSA). Don't bury the crown. Water in.
Environment	Sheltered, shaded spot until new leaf growth is well advanced and roots show at the drainage holes. Small divisions go in a humid house.
Time to establish	Small divisions need about 4–6 weeks in humid conditions (ANPSA); larger pieces re-establish in the shelter over a similar time.

Item	Details
Aftercare	• Harden off gradually – about a week with nights exposed, then a week in a sheltered spot, then into the open. • Keep foliage dry and airflow good to limit ink disease. • Pot on once roots fill the pot.

Common problems

Problem	Likely cause and fix
Division rots at the base	Too wet, too cold, or planted too deep. Pot at the original level; water less; divide in autumn.
Black spots spreading on leaves	Ink disease. Discard affected pieces; keep foliage dry; improve airflow.
Division wilts and dies	Too few roots or leaves not trimmed. Use larger pieces, trim leaves by a third, keep sheltered.

Notes

Difficulty	Moderate. Kangaroo paws divide well, but this species is shorter-lived than many hybrids, so divide young, healthy clumps. Seed is the main method.
Confidence	High. ANPSA publishes a detailed division method for kangaroo paws.
Sources	See References: 1, 2, 3, 5

Nursery records

Log each batch of divisions here to confirm or update the timing and difficulty above.

Date divided	Stock plant / provenance	No. pieces	No. established	Success %	Notes

Austrostipa flavescens

Coast Speargrass

Family
Poaceae

DIFFICULTY	DIVISION TYPE	BEST MONTHS	DIVISION SIZE	TIME TO ESTABLISH
Moderate *	Tussock division	Apr – Jun	Small clumps, 3-5 tillers	4-6 weeks

	Jan	Feb	Mar	Apr	May	Jun	Jul	Aug	Sep	Oct	Nov	Dec
Division	–	–	OK	Best	Best	Best	OK	–	–	–	–	–
	Best window		Workable – slower to re-establish or needs more care					Avoid / low success				

Plant snapshot

Habit	Tufted perennial grass, 0.2–1.2 m.
Flowering	Sep – Oct.
Habitat	Grey, red or calcareous sand, sandy loam and limestone; sand dunes.
Local note	Coastal species. Use nursery stock plants rather than digging from bushland.

Propagation options

Method	Suitability	Notes	Details in
Cuttings	Not used	Tufted grass.	–
Seed	Main method	Aged seed and smoke water; sow shallow.	→ Seed Sowing Guide
Division	Good	Divide established tussocks into small clumps.	This guide

Division method

Item	Details
Best time to divide	Apr – Jun, as autumn rain restarts growth. Mar and Jul are workable. Avoid Aug – Feb (flowering, seed set and summer heat).
Division type	Tussock division – a clump is split into smaller clumps of shoots (tillers), each with roots.
Division size	Small clumps of 3-5 tillers with a good root mass. Very small pieces establish poorly.
Selecting stock	Healthy, established pot-grown clumps that are actively growing.
Preparation	- Water the stock plant the day before. - Knock the clump out and tease or cut it apart with a sharp knife or spade. - Trim damaged roots. - Cut the leaves back to about 10–15 cm to reduce water loss.
Potting	Pot into a free-draining mix at the original depth. Firm in and water well.
Environment	Shade house until new leaves appear. Keep the mix moist, not wet.
Time to establish	Roughly 4-6 weeks in autumn. Record your results.
Aftercare	- Move gradually to full sun once new growth shows. - Pot on or plant out in winter.

Common problems

Problem	Likely cause and fix
Divisions brown off	Too small, or roots dried out. Keep 3–5 tillers per piece; work quickly in the shade.
Base rots	Too wet or planted too deep. Pot at the original level; water less.
No new growth	Divided in the wrong season. Divide as autumn growth starts.

Notes

Difficulty	Moderate (provisional). Grass clumps usually divide readily, but this species hasn't been tested here. Seed is the main method.
Confidence	Low. Division of established clumps works for this grass, but no species-specific method is published. Follows general tussock-grass practice – trial protocol.
Sources	See References: 1, 3

Nursery records

Log each batch of divisions here to confirm or update the timing and difficulty above.

Date divided	Stock plant / provenance	No. pieces	No. established	Success %	Notes

Dianella revoluta

Blueberry Lily / Flax Lily

Family
Asphodelaceae
(Hemerocallidoideae)

DIFFICULTY		DIVISION TYPE				BEST MONTHS		DIVISION SIZE		TIME TO ESTABLISH			
Easy		Rhizome clump division				Mar – May		3-4 shoots with rhizome		4-6 weeks			
		Jan	Feb	Mar	Apr	May	Jun	Jul	Aug	Sep	Oct	Nov	Dec
Division		-	OK	Best	Best	Best	OK	-	OK	OK	OK	-	-
Best window		Workable – slower to re-establish or needs more care						Avoid / low success					

Plant snapshot

Habit	Rhizomatous, tufted perennial herb, 0.3–1.5 m.
Flowering	Sep – Dec (blue-purple), followed by blue berries.
Habitat	White or yellow sand, sandy clay, laterite, loam and clay.
Local note	Recorded in Joondalup and Wanneroo. Division is much quicker than seed, which is slow and erratic.

Propagation options

Method	Suitability	Notes	Details in
Cuttings	Not used	Clumping herb.	–
Seed	Difficult	GA + smoke water; 8–11 weeks.	→ Seed Sowing Guide
Division	Main method	The quickest way to produce plants.	This guide

Division method

Item	Details
Best time to divide	Mar – May, so divisions root before winter. Feb, Jun and Aug – Oct are workable. Avoid Nov – Jan (heat) and Jul (cold).
Division type	Rhizome clump division.
Division size	Three or four leaf shoots with a good section of rhizome and healthy roots (ANPSA). Single shoots need a humid house.
Selecting stock	Vigorous clumps with plenty of shoots. Keep forms and provenances separate.
Preparation	- Water the stock plant the day before. - Lift the clump and shake or wash off the mix. - Cut the rhizome into pieces with a clean, sharp knife. - Trim damaged roots and cut leaves back by about one-third to one-half.
Potting	Pot into a free-draining native mix at the original depth. Water in.
Environment	Sheltered, shaded spot (humid house for small pieces) until new growth starts.
Time to establish	About 4–6 weeks in autumn.
Aftercare	- Harden off gradually – about a week with nights exposed, then a sheltered week. - Pot on once roots fill the pot.

Common problems

Problem	Likely cause and fix
Divisions wilt	Leaves not trimmed or too few roots. Trim harder; use bigger pieces.
Rhizome rots	Too wet or planted too deep. Water less; pot at the original level.
Slow to re-shoot	Divided in cold weather. Divide in autumn or spring.

Notes

Difficulty	Easy. Clump-forming lilies divide readily, and this is the quickest way to produce plants.
Confidence	Medium. ANPSA lists <i>Dianella</i> among the grass-like clumps suited to division; details follow the general method.
Sources	See References: 1, 3

Nursery records

Log each batch of divisions here to confirm or update the timing and difficulty above.

Date divided	Stock plant / provenance	No. pieces	No. established	Success %	Notes

Spinifex hirsutus

Hairy Spinifex

Family
Poaceae

DIFFICULTY	DIVISION TYPE	BEST MONTHS	DIVISION SIZE	TIME TO ESTABLISH
Moderate–Difficult *	Tussock division	Mar – May	Rooted clumps with runners	Slow – several weeks

	Jan	Feb	Mar	Apr	May	Jun	Jul	Aug	Sep	Oct	Nov	Dec
Division	OK	OK	Best	Best	Best	–	–	–	OK	OK	OK	OK
	Best window	Workable – slower to re-establish or needs more care						Avoid / low success				

Plant snapshot

Habit	Rhizomatous, tussock-forming grass, 0.3–0.9 m, with long runners and silvery, hairy leaves.
Flowering	Oct – Jan. Male and female flowers on separate plants.
Habitat	White sand on coastal dunes.
Local note	Recorded in the City of Joondalup. Dune plants are protected – use nursery stock or approved salvage.

Propagation options

Method	Suitability	Notes	Details in
Cuttings	Good	Runner (stolon) sections with 1–2 nodes.	→ Cuttings Guide
Seed	Main method	The usual nursery method; cover seed (needs dark).	→ Seed Sowing Guide
Division	Possible	Tussock divisions work but survived less well than rooted runners.	This guide

Division method

Item	Details
Best time to divide	Mar – May, while growing actively, giving plants ready for winter planting. Sep – Feb workable. Avoid Jun – Aug.
Division type	Tussock division – small clumps with rooted runners.
Division size	Small clumps with as much root and rooted runner as possible .
Selecting stock	Vigorous nursery stock plants. Collect male and female plants if you want seed-producing plantings later.
Preparation	- Keep pieces moist and shaded – they dry out fast. - Cut clumps apart with a sharp spade or knife. - Trim leaves back by about half.
Potting	Pot into deep tubes of coarse sand or a very sandy mix. Firm in and water well.
Environment	Shade house or light shade until new growth shows; keep the sand moist, not wet.
Time to establish	Slow – allow several weeks for new roots and shoots. Plants take many months to reach planting size.
Aftercare	- Harden off, then grow on in full sun. - Plant out in late autumn or winter when rain is reliable.

Common problems

Problem	Likely cause and fix
Divisions dry out and die	Roots exposed too long. Work in the shade; keep pieces in damp bags.
Base rots	Mix too wet. Use coarse sand, water less.
Slow establishment	Normal for spinifex. Full sun once hardened; deep tubes.

Notes

Difficulty	Moderate-Difficult (provisional). Divisions survived less well than rooted runner cuttings in trials. Runner cuttings or seed are usually better choices.
Confidence	Medium. Based on <i>S. sericeus</i> trials, where divided tussocks survived less well (31%) than rooted runner cuttings (40%).
Sources	See References: 3, 4

Nursery records

Log each batch of divisions here to confirm or update the timing and difficulty above.

Date divided	Stock plant / provenance	No. pieces	No. established	Success %	Notes

Spinifex longifolius

Beach Spinifex

Family
Poaceae

DIFFICULTY	DIVISION TYPE	BEST MONTHS	DIVISION SIZE	TIME TO ESTABLISH
Moderate–Difficult *	Tussock division	Mar – May	Rooted clumps with runners	Slow – several weeks

	Jan	Feb	Mar	Apr	May	Jun	Jul	Aug	Sep	Oct	Nov	Dec
Division	OK	OK	Best	Best	Best	–	–	–	OK	OK	OK	OK
Best window												
Workable – slower to re-establish or needs more care												
Avoid / low success												

Plant snapshot

Habit	Rhizomatous, tussock-forming grass, 0.3–1 m high and up to 2 m wide, with long runners.
Flowering	Apr – Dec or Jan. Male and female plants are separate.
Habitat	White sand on coastal dunes; a key foredune stabiliser.
Local note	Recorded in the Wanneroo LGA. Dune plants are protected – use nursery stock or approved salvage.

Propagation options

Method	Suitability	Notes	Details in
Cuttings	Good	Runner (stolon) sections with 1–2 nodes.	→ Cuttings Guide
Seed	Main method	The usual nursery method; smoke water, about 10 days.	→ Seed Sowing Guide
Division	Possible	Tussock divisions work but survived less well than rooted runners.	This guide

Division method

Item	Details
Best time to divide	Mar – May, while growing actively, giving plants ready for winter planting. Sep – Feb workable. Avoid Jun – Aug.
Division type	Tussock division – small clumps with rooted runners.
Division size	Small clumps with as much root and rooted runner as possible .
Selecting stock	Vigorous nursery stock plants.
Preparation	- Keep pieces moist and shaded – they dry out fast. - Cut clumps apart with a sharp spade or knife. - Trim leaves back by about half.
Potting	Pot into deep tubes of coarse sand or a very sandy mix. Firm in and water well.
Environment	Shade house or light shade until new growth shows; keep the sand moist, not wet.
Time to establish	Slow – allow several weeks for new roots and shoots.
Aftercare	- Harden off, then grow on in full sun. - Plant out in late autumn or winter when rain is reliable.

Common problems

Problem	Likely cause and fix
Divisions dry out and die	Roots exposed too long. Work in the shade; keep pieces in damp bags.
Base rots	Mix too wet. Use coarse sand, water less.
Slow establishment	Normal for spinifex. Full sun once hardened; deep tubes.

Notes

Difficulty	Moderate-Difficult (provisional). Divisions survived less well than rooted runner cuttings in trials. Runner cuttings or seed are usually better choices.
Confidence	Medium. Based on <i>S. sericeus</i> trials, where divided tussocks survived less well (31%) than rooted runner cuttings (40%).
Sources	See References: 3, 4

Nursery records

Log each batch of divisions here to confirm or update the timing and difficulty above.

Date divided	Stock plant / provenance	No. pieces	No. established	Success %	Notes

References

Numbers match the source list on each species page. Web addresses shortened; accessed September 2026.

#	Source	Address
1	Australian Native Plants Society (ANPSA) – Plant Propagation: division and layering (grass-like clumps, suckers, self-layering plants; division size, timing, hardening off)	anpsa.org.au/plant-propagation/
2	ANPSA – Kangaroo Paws & Relatives: propagation by division (autumn, 3+ shoots, trim leaves by a third)	anpsa.org.au/genera/kangaroo-paw-family/
3	FloraBase, WA Herbarium (DBCA) – species profiles (descriptions, flowering, habitat, local records)	florabase.dbca.wa.gov.au
4	NZ Department of Conservation – Rehabilitation of coastal foredunes using indigenous sand-binding species (<i>Spinifex sericeus</i> division vs stolon cuttings)	doc.govt.nz/Documents/science-and-technical/sfc122.pdf
5	Wikipedia – <i>Anigozanthos manglesii</i> (short-lived habit, ink disease)	en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Anigozanthos_manglesii

Revision log

Version	Date	Changes
1.0	Sep 2026	First edition: <i>Anigozanthos manglesii</i> , <i>Austrostipa flavescens</i> , <i>Dianella revoluta</i> , <i>Spinifex hirsutus</i> , <i>S. longifolius</i> . Includes a list of other species in the Cuttings and Seed guides that can be divided or layered.